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Epistemological Disenfranchisement in the Humanitarian Sector

How Global North Metrics Marginalize Indigenous Knowledge Management

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This thesis is submitted for obtaining the Master's Degree in International Humanitarian Action. By submitting the thesis, the author certifies that the text is from his/her hand, does not include the work of someone else unless clearly indicated, and that the thesis has been produced in accordance with proper academic practices.

Abstract

This thesis investigates the friction between reporting metrics derived from the Global North and Indigenous Knowledge Management (IKM) through an institutional ethnography of Cruz Vermelha de Timor-Leste (CVTL), the Red Cross National Society in Timor-Leste.

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Acknowledgements

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Key Concepts

Accountability to Affected Populations: The commitment of humanitarian actors to be answerable to the people they serve, ensuring that communities have a voice in decisions affecting them and can provide feedback or lodge complaints.

Do No Harm: A foundational principle requiring that interventions — including technological ones — must not cause unintended harm to affected populations. Derived from medical ethics and formalised in humanitarian practice.

Humanitarian Principles: The four core principles guiding humanitarian action: humanity, neutrality, impartiality, and independence. Established by the International Committee of the Red Cross and endorsed by the United Nations.

1 Introduction

CVTL is a humanitarian organization that operates in a post-colonial context, where the legacy of Portuguese colonization as well as the subsequent invasion and genocide committed by Indonesian forces has shaped the socio-political landscape. As an auxiliary to the government, the organization's work encompasses a range of humanitarian activities, including disaster response, health services, and community development. CVTL currently faces a persistent communication chasm where formal reporting metrics demanded by international donors and the International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies (IFRC) differ from CVTL's organizational practices. International organizations, like the Red Cross Movement, are institutions with structures of behavior and practice that are expected to be followed by their partners and National Societies, like CVTL. The reporting metrics demanded by donors and the IFRC are standardized across the humanitarian sector and are designed to create accountability and demonstrate effectiveness. It seems, however, that the behaviors and practices that are being demanded by the funding bodies and institutional structures seem not to align with the preferred practices of the local staff at CVTL. Lack of reporting is, of course, a significant concern for the donors. Lack of adherence to the reporting requirements can lead to loss of funding and resources, which can have serious consequences for the organization's ability to carry out its humanitarian work. The disconnect between the reporting metrics and the practices of local staff can also lead to a lack of trust and credibility with donors, which can further jeopardize funding and resources. This misalignment between demands and practices may be an anomaly to CVTL, but it is also very possible that this is an issue that is widespread across the humanitarian sector, particularly for organizations operating in post-colonial contexts with strong oral traditions and different ways of sharing knowledge. The purpose of this thesis is to investigate whether CVTL's lack of adherence to the standardized reporting metrics is a localized organizational issue or if it is symptomatic of a wider structural incongruence between preferred practices of humanitarian workers from the working contexts and that of global humanitarian structures of project cycle management.

1.1 Surviving in the system

The humanitarian sector operates with a fundamental tension between local autonomy and standardization—derived from and imposed by Global North institutions—in the name of accountability. For organizations like CVTL, this tension manifests in the need to navigate the demands of international donor bodies while also maintaining their own practices and priorities that are rooted in local contexts and cultures. In order to enjoy the confidence of its donors, CVTL must demonstrate its effectiveness and accountability to them while also ensuring that its work remains relevant and responsive to the needs of the communities it serves. The adoption of reporting metrics of their donors and the Federation can be seen as a strategy for CVTL to survive and thrive within the international humanitarian system as it allows access to funding and resources that are essential for their operations. This strategy, however, also comes with risks as it may lead to a misalignment between the preferred practices of the local staff and the practices demanded by donors. Technical upgrades, such as the implementation

of digital reporting systems, are often seen as a solution to these challenges but they may not actually address the underlying issues of structural incongruence. Local practitioners may find themselves navigating a complex web of reporting requirements that do not align with their preferred ways of sharing knowledge or value the information they deem important, leading to frustration and a sense of disempowerment. The rigid, “ordered” reporting systems are demanded by the international institutions and donors that supply the funding to partner organizations in the Global South and are standardized across the humanitarian sector in an effort to professionalize the sector and create accountability. The problem is that these systems are not context-based and instead impose a one-size-fits-all approach to knowledge management that may not be suitable for all organizations, particularly those operating in post-colonial contexts with strong oral traditions. Local humanitarian workers may find themselves becoming “custodians of comprehension”(Johar, 2025) —bureaucrats tallying the numbers and filling out the forms to satisfy donor requirements—rather than “catalysts for transformation”(Johar, 2025) —practitioners who are able to use their local knowledge and expertise to drive meaningful change in their communities. And so, partner organizations in the Global South, like CVTL, and their staff are left to negotiate their legitimacy within the system while navigating the power dynamics in which they are dependent on the funding and resources provided by the Global North institutions and donors.

1.1.1 Problem Statement

The data that is being reported and the information that is not are both important to understand the dynamics of knowledge production and power in the humanitarian sector. By examining the case of CVTL, this thesis seeks to shed light on the broader dynamics of knowledge production and power in the humanitarian sector and to contribute to ongoing discussions about decolonizing humanitarianism and valuing diverse forms of knowledge.

1.2 Research Question

The research aims to answer the following research question:

How does the “culture of comprehension”(Katsamangos, 2025) —the bureaucratic demand for ordered, standardized reporting metrics— function as a mechanism of communicative disenfranchisement for local humanitarian workers in the Global South and in what ways do these actors navigate the tension between local knowledge management practices and the demands of international donors?

1.2.1 Study Objectives

1. How do CVTL staff perceive the effectiveness of mandated digital reporting tools?
2. How do current reporting mechanisms impose an “ordered bias” that forces complex, context-specific knowledge into rigid, standardized formats?

3. How do local leaders within organizations navigate the tension between the demands of international donors and the compulsions of local knowledge management practices?

1.3 Methodology

This research utilizes a qualitative, decolonial institutional ethnography to investigate the communicative processes that shape knowledge management within the humanitarian sector. The study is grounded in the case of CVTL, serving as an entry point to analyze the broader “documentary reality” (Smith, 1990 cited in (Escobar, 1995), p. 107) created by donor institutions in the humanitarian sector. The mixed-method research will involve a combination of participant observation, semi-structured interviews, and document analysis to gather data on the experiences and perspectives of local humanitarian workers at CVTL. Document analysis will review institutional guidelines and reports, as well as digital tools (e.g., KoboToolbox) used for reporting, in order to understand the formal structures and expectations around knowledge management and reporting. Data analysis will be conducted using thematic analysis to identify key themes and patterns in the data. The conceptual structures for this thesis concern decolonial theory (Dorothy Smith, Arturo Escobar, Paul Sillitoe, Alan Bicker, and Johan Pottier), the Theory of Communicative Disenfranchisement (Elizabeth A. Hintz and Kristina M. Sharp), and the Cynefin Framework (Dave Snowden and Alessandro Rancati) to analyze the dynamics of knowledge production and power in the humanitarian sector.

1.3.1 Ethical Considerations

This study adheres to the UCD Low Risk Study protocols, ensuring that research is conducted with respect for the dignity of participants and without causing intentional harm.

- **Informed and Voluntary Consent:** All participants are fully briefed on the study’s purpose and provided written consent forms. They are informed of their right to withdraw at any time without penalty.
- **Confidentiality and Anonymity:** To encourage honesty and protect professional standing, all data is anonymized.
- **Data Sovereignty and Management:** Research is conducted in alignment with CVTL and IFRC data-sharing policies, with data stored securely according to university guidelines and accessible only to the research team.
- **Positionality and Bias:** The researcher acknowledges her positionality as an outsider to the local context and takes steps to mitigate bias through reflexivity and by prioritizing voices of local practitioners and perspectives from the Global South. The researcher also acknowledges the power dynamics inherent in the research process and strives to conduct the research in a way that is respectful to the participants. The researcher is also conscientious of the post-colonial context in Timor-Leste and her positionality as a person of Indonesian descent and a national of the United States of America—countries that bear responsibility for the genocide in Timor-Leste and its continued impact—and took care to approach the research with sensitivity.

1.3.2 Utility & Limitations

The research aims not only to produce academic knowledge but to offer practical insights that can inform the practices of CVTL and the wider humanitarian community. The findings will be shared with CVTL in order to contribute to their efforts in capacity building within the organization. The research also aims to contribute to ongoing discussions about improving knowledge management practices and addressing communicative disenfranchisement in the humanitarian sector.

The limitations of this research include the potential for bias in the data collection and analysis process, as well as the limited generalizability of the findings due to the focus on a single case study, that of CVTL. Additionally, the research may be limited by the availability and willingness of participants to share their experiences and perspectives, as well as by the constraints of time and resources. The researcher will take steps to mitigate these limitations through careful data collection and analysis, as well as by being transparent about the limitations of the study in the final report.

2 Literature Review

This literature review synthesizes existing research on the intersection of humanitarianism and development work, decolonial theory, and philosophical inquiries of knowledge. The review is structured around three main themes: (1) the bureaucratization of information through standardized reporting mechanisms, (2) the disenfranchisement of local humanitarian workers in knowledge production, and (3) how these humanitarians navigate the tension between the demand for standardized reporting and the complexity of their lived experiences.

2.1 Conceptual Frameworks

The Cynefin Framework was “designed to manage anthro-complexity, or complexity in human systems” (p. 57). Limitations of the framework include its focus on organizational decision-making and its potential oversimplification of complex social phenomena. However, it provides a useful lens for understanding the challenges of knowledge management in humanitarian contexts. Methodologically, because the Cynefin framework is utilized as a “decision support framework” rather than a predictive model, the findings are intended to offer diagnostic perspective and “sense-making” rather than “context-free” or “standard solutions” (Company, 2023). Furthermore, as participants reflect on past reporting challenges, the data is subject to the risk of retrospective coherence, where individuals may inadvertently reframe their original state of “aporetic” confusion into a more structured and logical narrative that masks the initial complexity of the experience ((Snowden and Rancati, 2021), p. 61.) Finally, the findings must be viewed through the lens of “bounded applicability,” recognizing that the insights derived from this case study may not be universally generalizable but can offer valuable perspectives for similar contexts and contribute to broader theoretical discussions in the field of humanitarian knowledge management ((Snowden and Rancati, 2021), p. 69).

2.1.1 Bureaucratization of Information

2.1.2 Disenfranchisement of Local Humanitarian Workers in Knowledge Production

2.1.3 Navigating the Tension Between Standardized Reporting and Lived Experiences

3 Methodology

3.1 Participant Selection

The study will include:

- Local humanitarian workers at CVTL who are involved in knowledge management and reporting processes.
- Staff from CVTL's donor organizations who interact with CVTL's reporting and knowledge management systems.
- Representatives from other donor institutions working in both Timor-Leste and elsewhere in order to provide insights into the broader context of the donor-recipient relationship and its impact on knowledge management practices.

3.2 Data Collection

Data will be collected through a combination of qualitative and quantitative methods, including:

- Semi-structured interviews with local humanitarian workers and donor representatives to explore their experiences, perspectives, and challenges related to knowledge management and reporting.
- Document analysis of CVTL's reporting templates, guidelines, and other relevant materials to understand the formal structures and expectations around knowledge management.
-

3.3 Data Analysis

Data will be analyzed using thematic analysis to identify key themes and patterns related to the research questions. The analysis will be guided by the Cynefin Framework, which provides a lens for understanding the complexity of knowledge management in humanitarian contexts, and the Theory of Communicative Disenfranchisement, which offers insights into the power dynamics and marginalization of local voices in knowledge production. The findings will be interpreted with existing literature on humanitarianism, decolonial theory, and knowledge production in mind.

4 Discussion and Analysis

But with such standardization of metrics, one must ask whose stories are being told and how? What knowledge is being valued and what is being left out? What type of information can be measured?

4.1 Findings in Relation to the Study Objectives

The findings of this study will be analyzed in relation to the three main themes through the study objectives:

1. How do CVTL staff perceive the effectiveness of mandated reporting tools?
2. How do current reporting mechanisms impose an ordered bias?
3. How do local humanitarian workers navigate the tension between the demand for standardized reporting and the complexity of their lived experiences?

4.1.1 Perceptions of Mandated Reporting Tools

4.1.2 Ordered Bias in Reporting Mechanisms

4.1.3 Navigating the Tension

4.2 Implications for Practice

5 Conclusions

This thesis aims to explore these questions through a case study of CVTL with a focus on understanding how reporting metrics are shaping knowledge management practices and if this may be leading to epistemological disenfranchisement. In the humanitarian sector information carries the weight of life-saving decisions as it determines resource allocation. The way information is produced, shared, and valued can have profound implications for the effectiveness and equity of humanitarian work. This clear misalignment between demands and practices could be leading to epistemological disenfranchisement, where the value of IKM is marginalized in favor of metrics that are more easily quantifiable and aligned with Global North institutions' efforts to standardize and "professionalize" (Escobar, 1995) the humanitarian sector.

5.1 Answers to Research Questions

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5.2 Final Conclusions

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5.3 Constraints and Limitations

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5.4 Recommendations

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A Interview Guide

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A.1 Background Questions

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A.2 Core Theme Questions

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A.2.1 Sub-Question Block

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A.3 Closing Questions

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B Codebook

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B.1 Primary Codes

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B.2 Secondary Codes

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C Yet Another Appendix

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C.1 Heading Level 1

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C.2 Heading Level 2

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